

Too Late to Say Goodbye

Emma slammed the drawer shut. A few wisps of dust floated through the air as the old wooden desk vibrated from the impact. Emma hated cleaning the attic room. It had been six months since her mother died, and since then, she had struggled to throw away all the clutter of memories that had littered the place. She wiped the sweat rolling down her face and opened another drawer.

Photographs and bills. At first, she thought they were bills. But then she noticed the writing. The letters had been addressed to her. Her stomach twisted into a knot. She recognized the handwriting. It was the last person she ever wanted to see again. The man who had abandoned her. Her father. Her father, who she hadn't seen since she was five years old. She threw the bundle of letters back in the drawer and turned away. "Too late," she muttered. She had spent years imagining what she would say to him if she ever saw him again. Every single word was vile. Her mother had worked two jobs in order to give them a stable life. She had sacrificed her vacations, birthdays, and holidays. While her mother suffered, her father was off somewhere else, enjoying his own life. That was what she thought, at least. Emma turned away from the drawer and tried to shake the letters from her mind. They wouldn't leave.

That night, Emma couldn't sleep. The picture of the letters was burned into her mind. So, just after midnight, she found herself back in the attic, standing in front of the old desk. It seemed deathly quite. The house was silent. Emma unfastened the ribbon and opened the first letter.

Dear Emma,

Today is your sixth birthday. I wish I were there to buy you a pink-frosted cake because your mother said that's your favorite flavor. I don't know if you're getting this letter or not, but I know that today, I prayed for you.

I prayed that you grow up healthy and happy

and that you always remember how much Jesus loves you.

Love,

Dad

Emma stared at the page in disbelief. This was not the letter she was expecting at all. She opened the next letter and then the next and the next. Each letter was dated on a different year, and each letter spoke to her. About her. Her first day of school. Her tenth birthday. The year she started playing basketball. The year her grandfather died. It was as if someone had somehow known her life and was watching over her. But then, every single letter had the same ending. A prayer. By sunrise, Emma had read nearly twenty letters. For the first time in years, she was speechless. And if her father hadn't cared at all, why had he continued to write to her?

The next morning, Emma paid a visit to her aunt Lydia. If anyone knew about the letters, it would be her. The two women sat in the kitchen, and Emma placed the bundle of letters on the table. Aunt Lydia's expression immediately changed. "Where did you get those?" she asked. "In Mom's

attic," replied Emma. Silence hung in the air. "Aunt Lydia," said Emma softly, "how could he write all those letters if he didn't care about me?" Her aunt looked down at the table. For a moment, she seemed to be searching for the right words. Then, she whispered, "Because he did care." Emma's heart skipped a beat. "What do you mean?" Her aunt's voice trembled. "There are some things that your mother never told you." The room suddenly seemed to shrink. "What things?" "Why do you think, Dad wrote all those letters if he didn't care about you?" Her aunt was quiet for a moment. Then she whispered, "Because he did care." Emma's heart pounded in her chest. "Care? What do you mean?" Tears glistened in her aunt's eyes. "There are some things your mother didn't want you to know." The room seemed to shrink. "Some things?" Her aunt inhaled deeply. "The reason your father left wasn't because he didn't love you."

Emma looked at her in disbelief. "Then why did he leave?" Her aunt hesitated before speaking. "He was arrested." The words came out in a rush. "He was accused of helping his friend commit financial fraud." Emma was stunned. "He was falsely accused," her aunt said firmly. "It turned out to be so years later. But by then, it was too late." Emma was overcome with grief. "Why didn't Mom tell me?" Her aunt shook her head. "She thought it would be better this way. She thought it would be better if you thought he left because he wanted to." Emma pushed back from the table. "Better? How could it be better?" Her voice cracked. "I spent my whole life hating him." There was a long pause. That night, Emma cried more than she had at her mother's funeral. Everything she thought she knew was crumbling around her. Over the next few weeks, she would read each and every letter. Thirty-seven letters in all. Some brought her hope, while others broke her heart. In one of them, he had thanked God for praying for her when she broke her arm. In another one, he had praised God for her straight A's. All of them guided her back to Christ, but they never led her to bitterness or vengeance. Only faith and forgiveness. At the bottom of the last letter, there was an address. The address of her father. Emma stared at it for a long time. Then, she made up her mind. She was going to see him. The bus ride would take four hours. During that time, she imagined their meeting. Would he recognize her? Would they hug? Would he apologize? Would she?

It was late afternoon when Emma arrived at the small town surrounded by hills. It led her to a modest white house. Her hands shook as she approached the front door. Before she could ring the doorbell, an old lady watering the flowers outside looked up. "Can I help you?" she asked. "I'm here to see Daniel Carter." The old lady's smile vanished. Oh, said the old lady. A strange feeling of disappointment coursed through Emma's veins. "Is he still here?" The old lady set down her watering can. "You don't know?" asked the old lady. Emma's heart pounded in her chest. "Don't know what?" The old lady hesitated before she replied. "He died three months ago." Silence. All Emma could hear was the old lady's voice. But somehow, it sounded as if it were coming from miles away. Three months. It had been three months since he died. Three months after thirteen years of hatred and anger. Three months after all those lies. And now, it was too late. The old lady was saying something, but Emma could barely hear her. She thanked the old lady and somehow managed to get back home.

That night, Emma sat on the floor of her room, surrounded by letters. Her eyes fell on one letter that had never been opened before. It was addressed to her, but somehow, it didn't seem as if it had come from her father. It read:

For Emma, in case I go before we meet

Trembling, she opened it. Dear Emma,

If you're reading this letter, it means that I'm with God. And if that's the case, then don't worry about me. Jesus Christ has been faithful to me throughout my time here. There was a time when I prayed every day that I would see you again. Maybe God answered my prayers in His own time and in His own way. I may never see you again in this life

But my fondest prayer is that God will grant us a meeting in heaven.

Don't put your trust in me, because I am only a man. Put your trust in Christ. He will never forsake His children. He will never fail them the way an earthly father does.

Love always,

Dad

At the foot of the page, there was a Scripture that read, "Believe on the Lord Jesus Christ, and thou shalt be saved," by Acts 16:31.

Emma looked up at the ceiling, tears streaming down her face. All those years of condemning a man who had loved her from afar had been meaningless. It all seemed to have been a waste of time. Now, it suddenly dawned on her that if her earthly father had been faithful to her, then how much more loving was her heavenly Father? Emma suddenly saw the Gospel in a new light. It was no longer just a sermon she had heard at church services all her life. It was no longer a collection of words written on a page. It was a Savior who had loved her even when she didn't know Him. It was a savior who had never failed her.

Emma was kneeling beside her bed, her letters scattered around her like pieces of a broken puzzle that had finally been put together. It was that night that she gave her heart to Jesus Christ through tears and prayers. Outside her window, the stars glittered in the dark sky. For the first time in a long time, Emma knew she had found peace. Not because all her questions had been answered. But because she had finally found the truth.